The London-born Efraim Halevy cuts a very different profile—soft-spoken, slightly rumpled, a newspaper tucked under his arm, his jowls pulled into a perpetual frown. Towards the end of our interview in a Tel Aviv cafe, he struggled to get the waitress's attention. "You see, nobody listens to me anymore," he chuckled.

He had a lengthy career in Israeli intelligence, but his best-known achievements (the public ones, at least) were as a diplomat. He forged close personal ties with King Hussein of Jordan, a relationship he used to help broker the historic 1994 peace treaty. Three years later, while Halevy was the Israeli ambassador to the European Union, Mossad tried to assassinate Hamas leader Khaled Meshaal on Jordanian soil, spraying him with poison on a busy Amman street. The bungled plot threatened to destroy the fragile agreement. Halevy was dispatched to Amman to help smooth tensions. (Again, Netanyahu sought to place the blame on his security chiefs, this time Danny Yatom, the head of Mossad; Halevy was soon brought out of retirement to head the agency.)

But for all his stylistic differences, he reached the same conclusions as Dagan. "All the time he's fighting, not only the Iranians, but fighting his base, his political base. [Netanyahu] is basically a very insecure individual," Halevy said. "He is a purveyor of fear in this country."

Indeed, he wondered if the prime minister was ever truly serious about striking Iran. As a politician, Netanyahu often proposes far-right ideas to appease his base, only to let them quietly wither—like his attempt at the "Jewish state bill", which was quickly dropped after the 2015 election. "It's unheard of that if the prime minister, the defense minster and the foreign minister together, all three of them are gunning for an operation, that all the rest would simply say no," Halevy said. "The theory which is being pushed around that, in his heart of hearts, he didn't want to do the operation, I think that's true. And therefore this whole charade, this major meeting and so forth, it was pointless."

"No daylight"

Six weeks after world powers signed the nuclear pact with Tehran, a billboard finally compelled Israelis to debate the subject. The advertisement, plastered over Rabin Square in mid-2015, announced the imminent opening of the "Iranian embassy in Israel". A phone number